WEEK 8 · LECTURE L1 · UNIT III

Multigenerational Workforces

What a generation is, what the evidence on generational differences shows, and the lifespan alternative to generational labels.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Explain Mannheim's concept of a generation and the age, period, cohort problem.
- Evaluate the meta analytic evidence on generational differences at work.
- Apply lifespan theories of age and motivation to workforce design.
- Explain how generational labels produce the ecological fallacy and age stereotypes.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 5 (create programs for multigenerational workforces).

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

A quality specialist with 22 years of service declines every move. Is that because of his generation?

Yes, no, or the question is wrongly posed.

WHAT A GENERATION IS · MANNHEIM (1952)

A generation is more than a birth year

GENERATION LOCATION

Born in the same period. Necessary, never sufficient: only a potential.

GENERATION AS ACTUALITY

Shared formative events in youth create a common stratum of experience.

GENERATION UNITS

Groups within one generation respond to the same events in different ways.

KEY POINT

Labels borrowed from the United States assume formative events that a worker in Ludhiana and one in Bengaluru may never have shared.

THE IDENTIFICATION PROBLEM

Age, period and cohort cannot all be separated

Design	Holds constant	Confounds
One survey in one year	Period	Age with cohort
Time lag: same age, different years	Age	Cohort with period
Longitudinal: same people over years	Cohort	Age with period

EXAM LENS

Cohort equals period minus age. Know any two and the third is fixed, so no single design isolates all three.

THEORY IN DEPTH · COSTANZA ET AL. (2012)

The meta analytic evidence

THE CORE IDEA

Generational differences in satisfaction, commitment and intention to quit are small, essentially zero in many cases.

HOW IT WORKS

Twenty studies, 19,961 people, 18 pairwise comparisons across four generations.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Mostly one time surveys, so generation is confounded with age and career stage.

IN PRACTICE

A firm that designs separate retention schemes for each generation targets differences that probably do not exist.

EXAM LENS

The authors conclude targeted generational interventions may not be effective. Cite this whenever a question invites stereotypes.

THEORY IN DEPTH · TWENGE ET AL. (2010)

Differences in work values over time

THE CORE IDEA

Using a time lag design, later cohorts valued leisure more and placed work less at the center of life.

HOW IT WORKS

Extrinsic values peaked with Generation X; later cohorts did not value altruistic work more, against popular claims.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Values of high school seniors in the United States, before full time work; cohort is confounded with period.

IN PRACTICE

A recruiter who markets "purpose" to young graduates as their defining value is not supported by these data.

EXAM LENS

Read it with Costanza: different constructs, different designs, different confounds. Neither supports stereotypes.

UNPACKING AGE · KOOIJ ET AL. (2008)

Five meanings of age

CHRONOLOGICAL

Calendar age.

FUNCTIONAL

Health, performance and cognitive ability.

PSYCHOSOCIAL

How old one feels and is seen to be.

ORGANIZATIONAL

Tenure, career stage and role.

AND THE FIFTH

Lifespan age: life events and family stage. A generational label collapses all five meanings into the first.

THEORY IN DEPTH · CARSTENSEN ET AL. (1999); KOOIJ ET AL. (2011)

A mechanism for age

THE CORE IDEA

Socioemotional selectivity: when time ahead feels open, goals favor growth; when it feels limited, they favor meaning.

HOW IT WORKS

Kooij et al. found age related positively to intrinsic motives and negatively to growth and extrinsic motives.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Social and security motives rose with age only in some subgroups; individual variation is large.

IN PRACTICE

A senior specialist may prefer deeper mastery to a promotion: a matter of perceived time, not generation.

EXAM LENS

A lifespan theory predicts the direction in advance. That is what a generational label has never done.

WHY LABELS CAUSE HARM

The ecological fallacy and age stereotypes

ROBINSON (1950)

Inferring an individual's attributes from a group level correlation is a fallacy.

POSTHUMA AND CAMPION (2009)

Age stereotypes at work are common, and much evidence refutes them.

KEY POINT

A generational program assigns a group average to every member and acts on beliefs the evidence does not support.

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

Why does a senior specialist decline a move?

Theory	Explanation	Design it implies
Generational	His cohort values stability	A cohort retention scheme
Socioemotional selectivity	A shorter horizon favors depth and meaning	Meaningful mastery work
Organizational age	Late career stage in a role he built	A career stage conversation

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"Managing generations is good engagement strategy." Critically evaluate using Costanza et al. and Twenge et al. **20 marks**

A strong answer: explains Mannheim and the identification problem; reports both studies accurately; offers the lifespan alternative; warns of stereotypes.

Design an engagement approach for a workforce aged 20 to 60 without using generational labels. **20 marks**

A strong answer: uses the five meanings of age and socioemotional selectivity; designs by life and career stage; addresses fairness.

What is the ecological fallacy? **10 marks**

A strong answer: defines it; cites Robinson; one example from workforce analytics.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. Measured generational differences at work are small, often near zero
2. Age, period and cohort cannot all be separated
3. Design for life and career stage, not for birth year

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

Costanza, D. P., Badger, J. M., Fraser, R. L., Severt, J. B., & Gade, P. A. (2012). Generational differences in work related attitudes: A meta analysis. *Journal of Business and Psychology, 27*(4), 375–394.

McKinsey & Company. (2022, July). The Great Attrition is making hiring harder. Are you searching the right talent pools? *McKinsey Quarterly*.

People Matters: selected articles on the employee lifecycle, as listed in the Lesson Plan.

Singh, S. K., & Singh, A. P. (2019). Interplay of organizational justice, psychological empowerment, organizational citizenship behavior, and job satisfaction in the context of circular economy. *Management Decision, 57*(4), 937–952.

HOW TO USE THESE

These are the Week 8 set readings. Costanza et al. (2012) is the core reading for this lecture. Note: the Lesson Plan lists Singh and Singh (2019) under the Journal of Indian Business Research; the verified published record is shown here.

Sources for this lecture (1 of 3)

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Carstensen, L. L., Isaacowitz, D. M., & Charles, S. T. (1999). Taking time seriously: A theory of socioemotional selectivity. *American Psychologist, 54*(3), 165–181. https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066x.54.3.165

Costanza, D. P., Badger, J. M., Fraser, R. L., Severt, J. B., & Gade, P. A. (2012). Generational differences in work related attitudes: A meta analysis. *Journal of Business and Psychology, 27*(4), 375–394. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10869-012-9259-4

Kooij, D. T. A. M., de Lange, A. H., Jansen, P. G. W., Kanfer, R., & Dikkers, J. S. E. (2011). Age and work related motives: Results of a meta analysis. *Journal of Organizational Behavior, 32*(2), 197–225. https://doi.org/10.1002/job.665

Sources for this lecture (2 of 3)

Kooij, D., de Lange, A., Jansen, P., & Dikkers, J. (2008). Older workers' motivation to continue to work: Five meanings of age: A conceptual review. *Journal of Managerial Psychology, 23*(4), 364–394. https://doi.org/10.1108/02683940810869015

Mannheim, K. (1952). The problem of generations. In P. Kecskemeti (Ed.), *Essays on the sociology of knowledge*. Routledge & Kegan Paul. (Original work published 1928)

Posthuma, R. A., & Campion, M. A. (2009). Age stereotypes in the workplace: Common stereotypes, moderators, and future research directions. *Journal of Management, 35*(1), 158–188. https://doi.org/10.1177/0149206308318617

Sources for this lecture (3 of 3)

Robinson, W. S. (1950). Ecological correlations and the behavior of individuals. *American Sociological Review, 15*(3). https://doi.org/10.2307/2087176

Twenge, J. M., Campbell, S. M., Hoffman, B. J., & Lance, C. E. (2010). Generational differences in work values: Leisure and extrinsic values increasing, social and intrinsic values decreasing. *Journal of Management, 36*(5), 1117–1142. https://doi.org/10.1177/0149206309352246